

The most common type of toner-based printer is the laser printer, which uses precision lasers to cause adherence. Laser printers are known for high quality prints, good print speed, and a low (Black and White) cost-per-copy. They are the most common printer for many general-purpose office applications. They are far less commonly used as consumer printers due to the high initial cost.

Laser printers are available in both colour and monochrome varieties. Another toner-based printer is the LED printer which uses an array of LEDs instead of a laser to cause toner adhesion to the print drum. Recent research has also indicated that Laser printers emit potentially dangerous ultra-fine particles, possibly causing health problems associated with respiration and cause pollution levels comparable to cigarettes. The degree of particle emissions varies with age, model and design of each printer, but is generally proportional to the amount of toner required. Furthermore, a well ventilated workspace would allow such ultra-fine particles to disperse, thus reducing the health side effects.

Inkjet printers spray very small, precise amounts (usually a few pico-litres) of ink onto the media. These droplets of ink will carry a slight electrical charge. The placement of the ink on the page is then determined by the charge of a cathode and electrode between which the ink moves towards the paper. Inkjet printing (and the related bubble-jet technology) are the most common—quality inkjet printers are inexpensive to produce.

Virtually all modern inkjet printers are colour devices. Some are known as photo printers and include extra pigments for improved reproduction of the colour gamut needed for high-quality photographic prints (and are additionally capable of printing on photographic card stock, as opposed to plain office paper).

Inkjet printers consist of nozzles that produce very small ink bubbles that turn into tiny droplets of ink. The dots formed are the size of tiny pixels. Ink-jet printers can print high quality text